

Hepatotoxicity Due To Hydroxycut®: A Case Series

Background Muscletech Hydroxycut® (Iovate Health Sciences Research, Oakville, Ontario) was a popular weight loss supplement that was recalled by the manufacturer in May 2009 based on reports of hepatotoxicity associated with this supplement. **Objective** To characterize the clinical presentation of Hydroxycut®-associated liver injury and to adjudicate these cases for causal association with Hydroxycut®. **Design** Case series. **Setting** Academic tertiary care hospitals and FDA databases. **Measurements** Assessment of causality and grading of severity of liver injury using methodology developed by the Drug-Induced Liver Injury Network (DILIN) study. **Results** Eight patients who developed liver injury after taking Hydroxycut treated at different medical centers were identified. All were hospitalized and 3 of 8 patients required liver transplantation. Nine other cases with adequate clinical information were obtained from the FDA MedWatch database including one fatal case of acute liver failure. Usual symptoms were jaundice, fatigue, nausea, vomiting and abdominal pain. Most patients exhibited a hepatocellular pattern of injury. Adjudication for causality revealed 8 cases as definite, 5 highly likely, 2 probable and 2 were considered as possible. **Conclusions** Hydroxycut® has been clearly implicated as a cause for severe liver injury that may lead to acute liver failure and death. Weight loss supplements represent a class of dietary supplements that should be regarded as capable of causing severe hepatic toxicity when the usual causes of identified liver injury cannot be otherwise elucidated.